

HANDBOOK

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MISSION, VISION, & VALUES

Mission

The WHSCL provides a fun and welcoming environment, encourages an active lifestyle, builds social bonds, and promotes a love for the sport of rock climbing to high school students across the state of Wisconsin through competitions and weekly practices.

Vision

To empower high school students to climb and to legitimize rock climbing as a competitive high school sport

Core Values

Fun & Welcoming: The WHSCL has been and always will be a welcoming environment for all Wisconsin high school students, regardless of any race, religion, political belief, social status, gender, sexuality, or ability. This environment is created by the collective of coaches in the league and through each and every student.

Active Lifestyle: Physical fitness is key to climbing and demands a certain level of dedication. Since each student climbs at a different difficulty, they are encouraged to find an individualized exercise plan that matches their goals. Ideally, this plan evolves into a healthy, active lifestyle.

Community: The fun and welcoming environment created by each team should organically lead to building social bonds. Our goal is to not only bring students together to be teammates but to also be friends. Climbing, although thought of as an individual sport, is a team activity. Students will need to rely on each other on and off the wall.

Love for Rock Climbing: Rock Climbing is not only a sport but also a lifelong activity. Students are encouraged to discover what they love about climbing to promote lifelong participation. While some students prefer top-rope climbing, others will prefer bouldering. No matter what discipline appeals to each student, our desire is to foster the enjoyment for the sport, as a whole.



CODE OF CONDUCT

INTRODUCTION & GUIDING PRINCIPLES

Introduction

The Wisconsin High School Climbing League (WHSC) is dedicated to providing a positive, inclusive, and respectful community for all student climbers. This Code of Conduct reflects our five Guiding Principles and outlines the standards of behavior expected from student athletes, coaches, parents/guardians, and volunteers.

Guiding Principles

Safety	Climbing involves inherent risks. We prioritize education, supervision, and adherence to safety protocols at all times.
Respect	We treat ourselves and others, our spaces, and our rules with dignity and care.
Sportsmanship	We compete with integrity, celebrate effort, support others, and show grace in victory and defeat.
Inclusivity	We welcome climbers of all backgrounds, abilities, and identities.
Responsibility	We hold ourselves accountable for our actions on and off the wall.



CODE OF CONDUCT

STUDENT ATHLETE EXPECTATIONS

Safety	• Follow all rules, protocols, and directions from coaches, gym staff, league organizers, and volunteer judges. • Use gear properly and check systems before climbing or belaying. • Speak up if you see an improper belay setup, gear being worn or used incorrectly, or rules being broken. • Be receptive to others approaching you about any potential safety concerns.
Respect	• Treat teammates, competitors, coaches, volunteers, gym staff, and league organizers with courtesy. • Care for gym equipment and climbing areas. • Follow the rules of the WHSCL, as well as facility rules of each climbing gym.
Sportsmanship	• Support teammates and competitors with positive encouragement. • Demonstrate honesty and integrity in all aspects of competition and training. • Refrain from using performance-enhancing drugs or any illegal substances.
Inclusivity	• Support and include all teammates and competitors regardless of background, ability, or identity. • Avoid the use of inappropriate language or behavior, including bullying, harassment, or discrimination of any kind.
Responsibility	• Arrive on time, prepared, and ready to participate. • Own your behavior in practice and competition. • Represent your team and the WHSCL with pride and integrity both in and outside of practices and competition settings.



CODE OF CONDUCT

COACH EXPECTATIONS

Safety	• Prioritize student athlete well-being through education on risk, risk mitigation, and proper gear and partner checks. • Ensure student athletes understand and follow climbing protocols, facility rules, and competition rules. • Supervise all training and competition environments attentively. • Complete SafeSport training annually and follow all SafeSport regulations.
Respect	• Model respectful and ethical behavior in all interactions, especially with student athletes, volunteer judges, other coaches, and league organizers. • Address concerns or conflicts in a calm, constructive way. There is no room for public criticism of anyone involved in the league. • Work collaboratively with other coaches, gym staff, and league organizers.
Sportsmanship	• Promote integrity, fairness, and encouragement above winning. • Encourage personal growth, team spirit, and sportsmanship over results. • Teach student athletes to compete with humility and respect.
Inclusivity	• Ensure every student athlete feels welcome, supported, and valued. • Create space for diverse skill levels and personal goals. • Foster a positive team environment, focused on learning and growth.
Responsibility	• Be prepared for practices and competitions. • Avoid the use of alcohol, tobacco, and illicit drug products when in contact with student athletes. • Communicate clearly with student athletes, parents, school administrators, and league organizers. • Represent your team and the WHSCL with pride and integrity both in and outside of practices and competition



CODE OF CONDUCT

PARENT & GUARDIAN EXPECTATIONS

Safety	• Understand and remind your child that climbing is an inherently dangerous sport. • Trust coaches and staff to educate your child about the risks involved in climbing and the steps to take to mitigate risk. • Reinforce gear checks, partner checks, and facility rules outside of team settings with your child
Respect	• Treat coaches, gym staff, league organizers, student athletes, and other parents with civility and support. • Refrain from coaching from the sidelines or interfering during competitions.
Sportsmanship	• Model positive behavior, regardless of outcomes. • Encourage your child to value effort, growth, and respect over rankings.
Inclusivity	• Encourage empathy and open-mindedness in your child. • Support your child's participation with encouragement and positivity. • Help uphold a positive, welcoming environment at practices, competitions, and league events.
Responsibility	• Ensure your child arrives at practices and events on time. • Maintain communication with coaches regarding absences and tardiness. • Address concerns through appropriate channels and in a respectful manner.



CODE OF CONDUCT

VOLUNTEER JUDGE EXPECTATIONS

Safety	• Help uphold rules and guidelines set forth by gym staff and league organizers at events. • Double check auto belays, climbing gear, and proper setup before allowing climbers to begin their Attempt. • Be alert to unsafe behavior and improper gear setup and report it promptly.
Respect	• Treat all student athletes, coaches, and spectators impartially and respectfully. • Treat all student athletes, coaches, spectators, gym staff, and league organizers with kindness and respect. • Maintain professionalism in tone, action, and decisions.
Sportsmanship	• Be consistent and fair when enforcing rules or judging. • Support a positive competitive environment. • Refrain from favoritism, discrimination, or unprofessional conduct.
Inclusivity	• Provide equal support to all student athletes and teams. • Recognize your stereotypes and mitigate their influence on your decision making
Responsibility	• Arrive on time, prepared to fulfill your role. • Follow through on commitments and report any issues.



CODE OF CONDUCT

FACILITY USE & STEWARDSHIP

These expectations apply to everyone:

- 1) Treat all climbing gyms, gym equipment, and shared spaces with respect and care.
- 2) Follow all posted rules and staff instructions at gyms and climbing facilities.
- 3) Clean up after yourself and leave shared spaces better than you find them.
- 4) When climbing outdoors, be mindful of environmental impact and follow Leave No Trace principles.

VIOLATIONS & CONSEQUENCES

Violations of this Code of Conduct may result in disciplinary action including, but not limited to:

- 1) Verbal or written warnings
- 2) Suspension from league events, practices, or competitions
- 3) Disqualification from competitions
- 4) Permanent removal from the league (in extreme cases)

All incidents will be reviewed by the WHSCL Director or an appointed disciplinary panel. Appeals may be allowed when appropriate.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Participation in WHSCL requires that all student athletes, coaches, parents/guardians, and volunteer judges read and agree to this Code of Conduct. Failure to follow policies, rules, expectations, and guidelines may lead to suspension or removal from some or all WHSCL activities and events.



ELIGIBILITY & PARTICIPATION

1. STUDENT ATHLETES

a) Student Athlete Eligibility

- i) Student Athletes must be current high school students in the state of Wisconsin.
- ii) Students not yet in high school may practice with a team but may not compete in WHSCL competitions.
- iii) Student Athletes are not required to compete or participate in competitions in order to be part of the WHSCL.

b) Student Athlete Fees

- i) To participate in the WHSCL, Student Athletes must pay an annual League Fee, which will be collected by Adventure Rock (owner of the WHSCL) when Student Athletes sign the Code of Conduct.
- ii) To practice with a team, Student Athletes must obtain access to their team's practice facility, which may require a daily or monthly membership fee.
- iii) If gear is needed, student athletes must purchase their own gear or pay for rental gear.
- iv) To compete, Student Athletes must pay the competition fee to the Host Facility.

c) Student Athlete Team Affiliation

- i) If the student attends a school with a team in the WHSCL, they should practice with their school's team; however, it is not required.
- ii) If a student stops attending a particular school at any time (i.e. moves or transfers), they are welcome to:
 - 1) continue to practice with their original team; or
 - 2) practice with their new school's team; or
 - 3) start a team at their new school, if their school does not have one.
- iii) High school students from any school in Wisconsin may practice with any team in the WHSCL; however, during competitions:
 - 1) the Student Athlete will compete under the name of the school they currently attend; and
 - 2) the Student Athlete's team points will go toward the school they currently attend.



ELIGIBILITY & PARTICIPATION

2. TEAMS

a) Team Eligibility

- i) In order for a team to exist in the WHSCL, it must have:
 - 1) Permission from the school to start a team, conduct weekly practices, and participate in competitions; and
 - 2) at least one Coach; and
 - 3) at least one Student Leader
- ii) It is recommended that each team recruit and maintain at least ten (10) student athletes at all times.

b) Practice Requirements

- i) Teams must schedule one weekly practice, to be held on the same day of the week, at the same time, and same location each week.
 - 1) If a team would like to hold regular practices more than one time per week, it must be pre-approved by the WHSCL Director at the beginning of the season.
 - 2) If a team would like to hold a pop-up practice on a different day, time, or location, it must be pre-approved by the WHSCL Director at least two weeks in advance.
- ii) Each practice needs to be attended by at least one Coach.
 - 1) If the appointed Coach cannot attend a practice, another adult (i.e. parent or community member) may attend in their place and will be given a free day pass with gear for practice.
 - 2) If the appointed Coach cannot attend a practice and another adult cannot attend, practice must be cancelled.
- iii) Any change to the practice schedule or attending coach should be communicated to the WHSCL Director as soon as possible



ELIGIBILITY & PARTICIPATION

3. COACHES

a) Coach Eligibility Requirements

- i) Coaches must be at least 18 years or older and may not currently be attending high school.
- ii) Coaches must not have a criminal history record. Coaches must be able to pass a criminal background check if requested to complete one.
- iii) There must not be any legal grounds restricting Coaches from interacting with youth.
- iv) If applicable, Coaches must complete all necessary paperwork and requirements set by the high school to lead the climbing team/club.
- v) It is preferred that each team have a faculty member from the team's school as a coach but will allow another adult (i.e. a parent or community member) to coach if a faculty member is not available, as long as it abides by school policy.
- vi) Climbing experience is encouraged but not required.

b) Coach Responsibilities

- i) Coaches are required to:
 - 1) All weekly team practices. If all coaches of a team are unable to attend a practice, the practice must be officially cancelled, and the Host Facility Manager of their practice location must be informed.
 - 2) Any events deemed mandatory by the WHSCL Director throughout the year, including but not limited to the Pre-Season Coaches' Meetings and any Coaches' Clinics.
 - 3) All competitions in which at least one of their students is competing. If all coaches of a team are unable to attend a competition, the coach(es) must appoint a parent/guardian of a student-athlete or a Student Leader to act as the team's coach during the competition. The coach(es) must inform the WHSCL Director of the coach absence and substitute coach in a timely manner before the competition.



ELIGIBILITY & PARTICIPATION

3. COACHES

- ii) Coaches are required to lead team practices with a focus on the well-being of all student athletes and a focus on rock climbing, including, but not limited to:
 - 1) Leading the team through climbing related activities.
 - 2) Facilitating warm ups and cool downs.
 - 3) Reviewing skills taught by Climbing Wall Instructors.
 - 4) Preparing student-athletes mentally and physically for competitions.
- iii) Coaches must remain in communication with the WHSCL Director throughout the year. Information and updates sent to the Coach by the WHSCL Director and/or Host Facility Manager must be relayed to the team by the Coach in a timely manner.
- iv) Coaches must meet all requirements set by the high school for which they are coaching.
- v) Coaches must commit to coaching for at least one whole season.

c) Coach Benefits

- i) Coaches receive a free family membership to their team's Host Facility, which will be valid from the day they sign this agreement until September 30th of the following season.
- ii) Each team is eligible for free annual family memberships for Coaches, based on the following guidelines:
 - 1) 1—15 student athletes — ONE family membership
 - 2) 16—24 student athletes — TWO family memberships
 - 3) 25—34 student athletes — THREE family memberships
 - 4) 35—44 student athletes — FOUR family memberships
 - 5) 45—54 student athletes — FIVE family memberships
 - 6) 55—64 student athletes — SIX family memberships
- ii) Coaches receive free admission to all WHSCL clinics and events, including but not limited to Yoga Clinics, Lead Climbing Clinics, and WHSCL End of Year Celebrations.



ELIGIBILITY & PARTICIPATION

4. STUDENT LEADERS

a) Student Leader Eligibility Requirements

- i) Student Leaders must be in high school, currently attending the school the team represents.
- ii) Student Leaders should be in good academic standing and hold a balanced schedule.
- iii) Climbing experience is encouraged but not required.

b) Student Leader Responsibilities

- i) Student Leaders are required to:
 - 1) attend all weekly team practices, unless excused by coach; and
 - 2) attend any events deemed mandatory by the WHSCL Director throughout the year; and
 - 3) attend all competitions; and
 - 4) commit to the Student Leader role for at least one whole academic year.
- ii) Student Leaders must remain in communication with their Coach and team throughout the year.
- iii) Student Leaders must assist their Coach in starting the team, running weekly practices, and maintaining a healthy team culture.

c) Student Leader Benefits

- i) Each team is eligible for 50% discounted memberships for Student Leaders, based on the following guidelines:
 - 1) 1—15 student athletes — ONE 50% off membership
 - 2) 16—24 student athletes — TWO 50% off memberships
 - 3) 25—34 student athletes — THREE 50% off memberships
 - 4) 35—44 student athletes — FOUR 50% off memberships
 - 5) 45—54 student athletes — FIVE 50% off memberships
 - 6) 55—64 student athletes — SIX 50% off memberships
- ii) Student Leaders receive free admission to all WHSCL clinics and events, including but not limited to Yoga Clinics, Lead Climbing Clinics, and WHSCL End of Year Celebrations.



ELIGIBILITY & PARTICIPATION

5. VOLUNTEER JUDGES

a) Volunteer Judge Eligibility

- i) Volunteer Judges must be 14 years of age or older.
- ii) Volunteer Judges may not be competing or registered to compete in the competition they are volunteering for.
- iii) Volunteer Judges for each competition must be available for the entire competition, from the start of the Volunteer Orientation to the end of Finals.
- iv) Volunteer Judges must review all volunteer material prior to arriving for the Volunteer Orientation on the day of the competition.
- v) Climbing experience is encouraged but not required.

b) Volunteer Recruitment Requirements

- i) Each team must provide Volunteer Judges for each competition, based on their total number of Student Athletes (not the number of competitors registered for a particular competition):
 - 1) 1—15 student athletes — ONE Volunteer Judge per competition
 - 2) 16—24 student athletes — TWO Volunteer Judges per competition
 - 3) 25—34 student athletes — THREE Volunteer Judges per competition
 - 4) 35—44 student athletes — FOUR Volunteer Judges per competition
 - 5) 45—54 student athletes — FIVE Volunteer Judges per competition
 - 6) 55—64 student athletes — SIX Volunteer Judges per competition
- ii) If a team is unable to provide the required Volunteer Judges for a competition, they may forfeit their right to compete in said competition.